

5 Scripts for the Hard Conversations

PT COMMUNICATION LAB — FREE RESOURCE

1. Patient hasn't done their exercises

"That happens. Was there something specific that got in the way this week?"

ALTERNATIVE: "Let us look at the exercise plan together. If it is too much or too hard to fit in, I want to know. We can adjust."

2. Patient is afraid to move

"I hear you. Fear of making it worse is completely understandable. Let us find a version that does NOT make it worse."

ALTERNATIVE: "What is the smallest, safest movement you feel willing to try today? Even a tiny one."

3. Patient is frustrated with slow progress

"I hear your frustration. You are working hard. Let me show you the progress you might be missing."

ALTERNATIVE: "Progress often looks like stairs, not a ramp. Flat periods, then jumps. You might be on a flat part right now. That is normal. The jump is coming."

4. Patient compares to someone who recovered faster

"That is frustrating. Here is what we know: age, starting fitness, tissue involvement, and even stress affect recovery speed. You are not your friend. Your body is on its own timeline."

ALTERNATIVE: "I cannot change your starting point. But I can help you maximize what you do now. Let us focus on what moves the needle for you."

5. Patient thinks rest is better than movement

"Complete rest for more than a few days can actually weaken muscles and stiffen joints. I am not saying push through pain. I am saying find the smallest amount of gentle movement that feels okay."

ALTERNATIVE: "If you need a few days of rest, take them. But let us put an end date on it. After three days, we start very small — even sitting and standing a few times counts."
